

Onions and Shallots.

DIFFICULTY

Not Difficult

2/5



HARVEST SEASONS
Summer / Autumn



Onions and shallots are among the most useful crops in the kitchen garden, providing fresh bulbs, salads, pickles and winter stores. Spring-planted sets offer a simple start; seed gives a wider choice of colours, sizes and seasonal types. Shallot bulbs usually divide into clusters, while overwintered onions provide earlier harvests.

Quick facts

Sow Feb – Apr; Aug	Harvest Jun – Sep	Germination 21 days	Depth 1.5 cm
Row spacing Between rows: Onions and shallots 30 cm; salad onions 20 cm	Plant spacing Between plants: Salad onions 2.5 cm; single seed-grown bulbs 10 cm; sets 10–15 cm; small module clumps 15 cm; shallots 15–20 cm		
Yield (3 m row) 3.6 kg	Ready in From planting: sets ~20 weeks, shallots ~18; from sowing: spring ~22, August ~46 weeks		

Growing calendar



Core needs

1 = low · 5 = high

Sun	4/5
Water	3/5
Nutrition	3/5

Recommended varieties

BULB ONIONS

Ailsa Craig

Large, round, straw-coloured bulbs with mild white flesh, popular for exhibition and kitchen use.

BULB ONIONS

Bedfordshire Champion

Large, round bulbs suitable for storage.

BULB ONIONS

Sturon

A round, straw-coloured storage onion, available as seed and sets.

BULB ONIONS

Rijnsburger

Large, round, pale-skinned onions with white flesh.

OVERWINTERED BULB ONIONS

Buffalo

An F1 hybrid for an early bulb crop from suitable spring or late-summer sowings.

BULB ONIONS

North Holland Blood Red

Red-skinned bulbs useful for cooking, colour and exhibition; also usable young.

Key risks



White Rot (Mouldy Nose)

White rot affects onions, shallots, garlic and leeks.



Allium Leaf Miner

Adult flies make distinctive rows of small white feeding punctures on allium leaves.



Bolting

Prolonged cold can trigger premature flowering, especially in large sets or young plants checked by weather.



Leek Moth

Leek-moth caterpillars can mine onion and shallot leaves and damage bulbs.



Growing & harvesting

Start with clean, firm ground.

Shallow roots need careful weeding, good drainage and steady moisture.

Dry storage bulbs thoroughly.

Only sound, well-ripened bulbs belong in the long-term store.

Soil & preparation

1. Choose an open, sunny site with fertile, firm, well-drained soil. Add well-rotted compost before planting; avoid fresh manure and excess nitrogen.
2. Rotate kitchen crops yearly. Rake a fine seedbed for seed-grown onions and test acid soil before liming.

Looking after the crop

1. Weed carefully around shallow roots; water in dry spells and use a thin compost mulch. Replant lifted sets and guard against birds.
2. Remove flower stems and use bolted bulbs early. Reduce watering as bulbs mature; allow foliage to yellow naturally.

Harvesting & storage

- Pull salad onions young. Lift mature onions as foliage yellows and falls; lift and separate shallot clusters when ready.
- Dry bulbs thoroughly on airy trays, under cover in wet weather. Store sound dry bulbs cool, airy and frost-free; discard rot and use sound damaged or thick-necked bulbs first.

Sowing & planting

1 Set



Set roots down in firm, weed-free soil.

2 Firm



Tip showing; firm and water. Net against birds.

Seed depth (not sets) 1.5 cm

Rows by crop Between rows: Onions and shallots 30 cm; salad onions 20 cm

Plants / clumps Between plants: Salad onions 2.5 cm; single seed-grown bulbs 10 cm; sets 10–15 cm; small module clumps 15 cm; shallots 15–20 cm

Seed route: sow thinly in drills or modules; plant multi-sown clumps intact.

Start bulb onions under cover in late winter or outdoors in spring. Seed gives wider choice; sets are simpler. Sow three or four per module for clumps.

Overwintering onions: late-August seed or September–October sets. Plant shallots in spring, or autumn/winter for suitable varieties on well-drained soil.

Pests & diseases

Problem	What to look for	What to do
White Rot (Mouldy Nose)	Yellowing; white mould at roots or base.	Remove diseased plants; keep alliums off infected ground.
Allium Leaf Miner	White puncture rows; internal larvae or pupae.	Mesh during fly activity; remove infested material.
Bolting	Flower stems develop before bulbs mature.	Use suitable or heat-treated sets; use bolted bulbs early.
Leek Moth	Leaf mines; caterpillars inside.	Remove infested leaves; mesh the rotated bed.
Downy Mildew	Grey mould on leaves; growth is checked.	Remove diseased growth; space well, drain and rotate.
Neck Rot	Stored bulb necks soften with grey mould.	Dry thoroughly; store sound bulbs and remove rots.
Onion Fly	Yellow, drooping leaves; maggots at base.	Remove infested plants; rotate and mesh.
Rust	Orange pustules; leaves may yellow.	Remove badly affected leaves; improve airflow.
Birds Pulling Sets	Newly planted sets are uprooted.	Replant and firm; protect with secure, taut netting.
Bull Neck (Thick Neck)	Thick, fleshy necks dry poorly.	Avoid excess nitrogen; use sound bulbs early.

Final tips



Unpack delayed sets and spread them in a cool, light place until planting.



Spring sets need suitable soil conditions; prolonged cold increases bolting risk.